

THE QUR'ANIC METHOD OF INVITING TOWARDS ISLAM



By: Mufti Muhammad Qasim Qadiri

The Qur'anic Method of Inviting towards Islam

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اَلْحَمْدُ لِلّٰهِ رَبِّ الْعٰلَمِيْنَ وَالصَّلٰوةُ وَالسَّلَامُ عَلٰى خَاتَمِ النَّبِيِّنَ
اَمَّا بَعْدُ فَاَعُوْذُ بِاللّٰهِ مِنَ الشَّيْطٰنِ الرَّجِيْمِ بِسْمِ اللّٰهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيْمِ

Allah Almighty states in the Holy Qur'an:

اَدْعُ إِلَى سَبِيلِ رَبِّكَ بِالْحُكْمَةِ وَالْمَوْعِظَةِ الْحَسَنَةِ وَجَادِلْهُمْ بِالَّتِي هِيَ أَحْسَنُ إِنَّ رَبَّكَ هُوَ
أَعْلَمُ بِمَنْ ضَلَّ عَنْ سَبِيلِهِ وَهُوَ أَعْلَمُ بِالْمُهْتَدِينَ ﴿١٢٥﴾

*Call towards the way of your Lord with wisdom and good counsel and argue with them in the best manner. Your Lord knows best he who has deviated from His way, and He knows best those who have attained guidance.*¹

Having the passion to serve Islam is a means of attaining success in the Hereafter, and fulfilling this duty is a great act of worship. However, just as every act of worship has its necessary rulings and etiquettes, those who invite people towards Islam and strive to safeguard it also have certain rulings and etiquettes. Some of these have been mentioned in the above verse. Let us examine some details of these matters in the light of this verse.

It should, however, be remembered here that the discussion below concerns general circumstances relating to inviting people towards Islam and preaching, as well as debate and discussion. The details given below do not encompass all the rulings in this regard. There are many other requirements of Islam which arise on different occasions, where the forms of expression, wording and wisdom employed vary. Such other methods and etiquettes are also established from the noble Qur'an, Hadith and the righteous predecessors. The discussion below relates to general circumstances. Moreover, throughout this discussion,

¹ Al-Quran, Al-Nahl, verse 125; translation from Kanz al-'Irfān

one should examine oneself rather than others, asking whether one fulfils these rulings and observes these etiquettes.

A study of the noble Qur'an and Hadith makes it clear that striving to reform people's beliefs and actions is among the fundamental teachings of Islam. Various methods are employed to fulfil this duty, including preaching and counsel, inviting towards righteousness, personal preaching, public speeches and addresses, and debate and discussion in the best manner.

There are countless benefits of employing all these methods effectively. For example, through efforts to invite towards Islam, people are freed from incorrect beliefs, come to recognise sound beliefs, and reform their beliefs and actions, as well as their morals and character. Their faith is revitalised; their hearts become acquainted with the recognition of Allah Almighty, filled with the love of Allah Almighty and brimming with the fear of Allah Almighty. They attain the blessing of closeness to the Beloved Prophet ﷺ and the treasure of love for the Merciful Messenger ﷺ. They develop a desire for the pleasure of Allah Almighty, an eagerness to attain reward, a longing for Paradise and a fear of Hell.

Likewise, individual, collective, family and social reform depends to a great extent upon inviting towards righteousness. However, it is clear that these benefits can only be attained when preaching and counsel are delivered in the appropriate manner, and when Islam is conveyed in accordance with the circumstances, the requirements of the age, people's psychology and the guidance of the Shariah, as Allah Almighty states in the verse mentioned at the beginning:

*"Invite towards the path of your Lord with wisdom and good counsel, and debate with them in the best manner."*¹

The honourable exegetes have provided a very comprehensive explanation of the important words of this blessed verse, making it easier to understand its true meaning. Let us first understand the meanings and implications of these words

¹ Part 14, Surah al-Nahl, 125

individually, and then consider the overall command.

He states:

أَدْعُ إِلَى سَبِيلِ رَبِّكَ

Call towards the way of your Lord

The path of the Lord refers to Islam, religion and the Shariah. Good morals, good social conduct, the desired outward and inward virtues, and indeed the Shariah rulings relating to all aspects of life are part of the path of Allah Almighty. Inviting people towards these things is therefore referred to as inviting them towards “**the path of Allah.**”

He further states:

بِالْحُكْمَةِ

with wisdom

Wisdom refers to the noble Qur'an and Sunnah.¹ It also refers to firm and definitive proofs through which the doubts of the person being addressed can be removed. Likewise, wisdom refers to correct and appropriate speech which has the best effect upon hearts.² It also includes knowing what appropriate words should be spoken regarding a particular action and on what occasion.

He further states:

وَالْمَوْعِظَةُ الْحَسَنَةُ

and good counsel

The meaning of “preaching and counsel” is to remind someone of reward and

¹ Tafsir Ibn Kathir, vol. 4, p. 613, Published by: Dar Tayyiba, Riyadh

² Rūh-ul-Ma'ani, vol. 7, p. 487, Published by: Dar-ul-Kutub-ul-Ilmiyah, Beirut

punishment and offer such counsel that softens their heart and leads them to accept the advice.¹ A further explanation of good counsel is that people should be reminded of the punishment that comes as a result of disobedience to Allah Almighty, the accounts of past nations and admonitory lessons, so that they fear the punishment of Allah Almighty and accept the counsel.²

Good counsel also includes inviting people towards the noble Qur'an and Sunnah, and towards Islam and the Shariah, with gentleness, compassion and good character, rather than with harshness, severity and a harsh tone.³ In other words, **good counsel** means combining encouragement with warning, and glad tidings with admonition: that is, giving people glad tidings of reward for righteousness while also warning them of punishment for sin.⁴

He further states:

وَجَادِلْهُمْ بِالَّتِي هِيَ أَحْسَنُ ط

and argue with them in the best manner.

Jidāl, that is, debate and discussion, is not in itself a method of inviting towards Islam. Rather, its fundamental purpose is to establish the proof against an opponent, leave them unable to respond and remove their stubbornness and obstinacy. For this reason, Allah Almighty has mentioned *jidāl* separately from inviting towards Islam, so that it becomes clear that the primary purpose of *jidāl* is to establish such an argument against an opponent that they become unable to respond or the invalidity of their position becomes evident.⁵

The fact that inviting towards Islam is not the primary purpose of debate does not mean that debate contains no element of invitation. Rather, it means that the primary and initial purpose of debate is to establish one's position and

¹ Rūh-ul-Bayan, vol. 5, p. 97, Published by: Dar Ihya-ut-Turath-ul-Arabi, Beirut

² Tafsir Ibn Kathir, vol. 4, p. 613, Published by: Dar Tayyiba, Riyadh

³ Tafsir Qurtubi, vol. 12, p. 461, Published by: Muassasat-ur-Risala, Beirut

⁴ Tafsir Nasafi, vol. 2, p. 242, Published by: Dar-ul-Kalim-ut-Tayyib, Beirut

⁵ Tafsir Kabeer, vol. 7, al-juz 20, p. 287, Published by: Dar Ihya-ut-Turath-ul-Arabi, Beirut

demonstrate the opponent's error. Ultimately, however, the aim is for the other person to understand their mistake and move towards accepting the truth, and this itself constitutes an aspect of inviting towards Islam.

Nevertheless, even in debate and disputation, an excellent manner should be adopted. For example, if an opponent makes personal attacks or causes distress, one should overlook this and remain focused on the actual subject and objective, establishing one's position in the best possible manner. Sayyiduna Mujahid

رَحْمَةُ اللَّهِ عَلَيْهِ has also stated that **وَجَادِلْهُمْ بَاتِّبِي هِيَ أَحْسَنُ ط** means that the harm caused by them should be disregarded.¹

Good conduct in debate also includes the representative of the true belief adopting gentleness, forbearance, good character, an easy style and commonly accepted premises.²

Complete Explanatory Meaning of the Verse

If the individual meanings of the words explained above are brought together and the complete explanatory meaning of the verse is considered in their light, it would be as follows:

Invite people towards the path of your Lord. Call them towards Islam, religion, the Shariah, good morals, good social conduct and the Shariah rulings relating to all aspects of life. This invitation should be made with wisdom; that is, invite them through Qur'anic verses and Prophetic Hadiths. Present such firm and definitive proofs before them that their doubts and misgivings are removed. Speak correctly and appropriately, in accordance with the circumstances, in a manner that has the best effect upon their hearts.

Your invitation of people towards the path of Allah Almighty should take the form of good counsel and excellent preaching. For example, give people glad tidings of reward for sound beliefs and righteous deeds, while conveying warnings of punishment for disbelief and sins in such a manner that their hearts

¹ Tafsir Tabari, vol. 14, p. 401, Published by: Dar Hijr, Qahira

² Rūh-ul-Ma'ani, vol. 7, p. 487, Published by: Dar-ul-Kutub-ul-Ilmiyah, Beirut

become softened and they accept the counsel. In preaching and counsel, tell people how previous nations were punished for disobeying Allah Almighty. Furthermore, adopt gentleness, compassion and good character in preaching, counsel, addresses and speeches, and avoid harshness, severity and a harsh tone.

Whenever the need for debate and discussion with someone arises in addition to preaching and counsel, establish such an argument before the opponent that the invalidity of their position becomes evident, ultimately enabling them to understand their mistake and move towards accepting the truth. If an opponent makes personal attacks or causes distress during debate, overlook this and remain focused on the actual subject and objective, establishing your position in the best possible manner. Debate with the person being addressed in a good manner; that is, as far as possible, adopt gentleness, patience, good character, an easy style and commonly accepted premises.

After understanding the commentaries cited above and the detailed meaning, it becomes easy to understand that this Qur'anic verse sets out three fundamental principles for inviting towards Islam and defending it:

1. Wisdom
2. Good counsel
3. Debate in the best manner

The First Method of Inviting Towards Islam: Wisdom

Using wisdom when inviting towards Islam is extremely important. Wisdom itself is a great virtue, perfection and divine blessing. Allah Almighty states:

يُؤْتِي الْحِكْمَةَ مَنْ يَشَاءُ ۚ وَمَنْ يُؤْتَ الْحِكْمَةَ فَقَدْ أُوتِيَ خَيْرًا كَثِيرًا ط

Allah confers wisdom to whomsoever He wills, and whosoever is granted wisdom has indeed been granted goodness in abundance.¹

¹ Al-Quran, Al-Baqarah, verse 269; translation from Kanz al-'Irfān

The one whose invitation is adorned with evidence from the noble Qur'an and Sunnah, based on firm proofs and suited to people's intellect and understanding, the circumstances, the situation and the need, and whose choice of words conforms to good manners and consists of simple rather than difficult expressions, will have people accepting their invitation.

On the other hand, where an invitation towards Islam contains no trace of the Qur'an and Hadith, consists of weak arguments and superficial statements, shows ignorance or negligence regarding the requirements of the age and people's circumstances, lacks dignity and decorum in its tone and style, substitutes harshness for gentleness, and adopts humiliation and degradation instead of presenting the truth, expecting positive results from such an invitation is like expecting to eat mangoes from a bitter-gourd plant.

It should also be borne in mind that when wisdom means definitive proofs, this method of invitation is employed with those who place great reliance on reason and intellectual understanding, because such people pay particular attention to whether an invitation is sound and certain, and are less inclined towards mere preaching and counsel. Therefore, such people should be invited towards the true religion through wisdom, that is, definitive and certain proofs. In the present age, the correct presentation of rational arguments, scientific facts and psychological effects can also prove highly effective in inviting towards Islam.

It is always beneficial to keep the following comprehensive principle in mind:

“كلموا الناس على قدر عقولهم”

Translation: “Speak to people according to their level of understanding.”

The Second Method of Inviting Towards Islam: Good Counsel

The general public are invited towards the path of Allah through good counsel, because rather than engaging in deep thought and reflection, they readily accept words that touch their hearts. Glad tidings of righteousness and warnings of Hell for sins have a prompt effect on such people, and most people belong to

this category.

Good counsel consists of sincere concern, gentleness, compassion and tenderness of heart. However, if people are constantly accustomed either to being frightened or to being given hope, then merely continuing to frighten them will cause them to lose hope in the mercy of Allah Almighty, while merely hearing about His mercy may make them heedless of action, as is commonly observed.

Weak narrations may be accepted in **Maw'izah Hasanah** (good counsel), but fabricated material can never be accepted, whether it consists of fabricated Hadiths or invented stories and tales. Likewise, the fluency of one's tone and manner of expression, along with the pleasing modulation of the voice, can make a speech or discourse highly effective, whereas shouting, roaring and scolding more often result in the invitation being rejected rather than accepted.

The Third Method of Serving Islam: Jidāl, or Debate

Jidāl, that is, debate and disputation, is also included in serving Islam. There continues to be a need for debate and discussion in serving Islam, supporting Islam and affirming and defending correct beliefs. This method is employed with people who have a greater tendency towards argument, dispute and opposition.

Even when debating such quarrelsome and antagonistic people, the noble Qur'an teaches us to converse in the best and most courteous manner, so that the truth becomes clear while good character is maintained, enabling the opponent's stubbornness to subside and bringing them closer to accepting the truth.

The Holy Qur'an has described the method of debate and disputation in highly comprehensive words: **"Debate in the best manner."** This essentially involves two things: first, the arguments themselves; and second, the manner in which those arguments are presented.

The first aspect to consider in jidāl, that is, debate and disputation, is the arguments. An argument should consist of matters that are accepted by everyone or that are acceptable to the opponent. For example, when debating a

Muslim, arguments from the Noble Qur'an and Hadith are generally accepted by all. When engaging in dialogue with a person of another religion, rational arguments and evidence from the recognised scripture of that religion can prove beneficial. When debating sects that identify themselves as Muslim, reference to an authority or book recognised by the other sect can be considered valid.

In any case, debate should be based on evidence. Instead of this, if the objective is to prove something through shouting and uproar, sophistry, deception and improper methods, or merely to humiliate the other person, then such an approach is unjust and unbecoming of people of virtue.

The second aspect of jidal, that is, debate and disputation, concerns the manner in which arguments are presented. In this regard, it should be noted that in the Holy Qur'an Allah Almighty mentions the conversations of various Messengers with their people and records that the noble Messengers عَلَيْهِمُ السَّلَام repeatedly said to them: **"We sincerely wish you well."**

Thus, the blessed words أَنْصَحُكُمْ *("I seek goodness for you,")*¹ and وَأَنَا لَكُمْ نَاصِحٌ أَمِينٌ *("and I am a trustworthy adviser to you.")*² occur at several places. These words show that even when engaging in debate and discussion, one should have sincere concern for one's opponent.

It is clear and self-evident that one cannot sincerely wish someone well while humiliating and degrading them. Rather, sincere concern must be shown in the manner that Allah Almighty taught Sayyiduna Musa and Sayyiduna Harun عَلَيْهِمَا السَّلَام when He sent them to Pharaoh.

When sending Sayyiduna Musa and Sayyiduna Harun عَلَيْهِمَا السَّلَام to a proud and rebellious person such as Pharaoh, Allah Almighty commanded:

¹ Al-Quran, Al-A'raf, verse 62; translation from Kanz al-'Irfan

² Al-Quran, Al-A'raf, verse 68; translation from Kanz al-'Irfan

*Speak to him with courtesy; perhaps he will heed 'your' advice or be fearful.*¹

If gentle speech was commanded even when dealing with a disbeliever such as Pharaoh, it can easily be understood how one should speak to disbelievers and misguided people who are less severe than Pharaoh.

Sayyiduna Isma'il Haqqi رَحْمَةُ اللهِ عَلَيْهِ states: "Jidāl refers to a debate that is based on truth and in which gentleness, forbearance, overlooking faults, good character, speaking according to people's level of understanding, consideration of the outcome, patience and endurance are adopted. The purpose of such debate should solely be to clarify the truth and manifest what is true, not to serve a personal interest or seek fame or victory. Furthermore, even towards opponents, no matter how stubborn or misguided they may be, one should maintain an attitude of sincere concern, compassion and sympathy. This is the true meaning of 'debating in the best manner'."²

Summary

Today, a large number of Muslims are distant from following the Shariah in their individual, family, social, economic and societal affairs because they are unaware of religious rulings and lack the motivation to act upon them, and this distance is continually increasing. Alongside this, there is a very large group that is averse to religion. Because they regard religion as an obstacle to fulfilling their desires, they themselves remain averse to religion and strive to make others averse to it as well. Indeed, openly denying religion in the name of liberalism is also becoming increasingly common.

Some of these people openly object to religion, but more often, instead of having the courage to raise explicit objections to religious matters, they present the speech, words and manner of scholars and religious people negatively in order

¹ Al-Quran, Al-Tā Hā, verse 44; translation from Kanz al-'Irfān

² Ruh al-bayan, vol. 5, p. 98, Published by: Dar Ihya-ut-Turath-ul-Arabi, Beirut

to make Muslims averse to religion.

In such a delicate situation, departing from the Qur’anic approach of wisdom and counsel and adopting harshness and severity does not reform people; rather, it supports those who are averse to religion. Therefore, the field of preaching and reform calls for the Qur’anic style itself that people are reformed through sincere concern, gentleness, compassion, reassurance and heartfelt sympathy. This is how religion can be served more effectively.

By contrast, harsh words, a humiliating manner and unwarranted criticism in inviting towards Islam often create hatred, stubbornness and distance in the heart of the person being addressed; they can even become a means of distancing those from religion who merely see or hear such conduct. Gentle speech, on the other hand, wins hearts.

For this reason, the Messenger of Allah ﷺ declared gentleness to be a cause of goodness. He ﷺ said:

“مَنْ أُعْطِيَ حَظَّهُ مِنَ الرِّفْقِ فَقَدْ أُعْطِيَ حَظَّهُ مِنَ الْخَيْرِ، وَمَنْ حُرِمَ حَظَّهُ مِنَ الرِّفْقِ فَقَدْ حُرِمَ حَظَّهُ مِنَ الْخَيْرِ”

Translation: “Whoever is granted a share of gentleness has certainly been granted a share of goodness, and whoever is deprived of a share of gentleness has certainly been deprived of a share of goodness.”¹

Questions for Those Serving Islam to Consider

After reading the blessed verse mentioned at the beginning and the explanations given by the honourable exegetes, every person serving Islam should now take a moment to reflect on their own manner and style of preaching, delivering speeches, addressing people and engaging in debate, and consider whether it conforms to the Qur’anic command or requires improvement. Here are some questions that every speaker and preacher can ask themselves:

¹ Sunan al-Tirmidhi, Kitab al-Birr wa al-Ṣilah, Bāb mā jā’a fi al-Rifq, vol. 3, pp. 407–408, Hadith 2020, Dār al-Fikr, Beirut

- (1) When preaching and offering counsel, do I present the Noble Qur'an and Hadith, as well as reliable events and evidence, or do I try to impress people with fabricated narrations, unverified Hadiths and unauthenticated stories?
- (2) Do I speak according to the audience's intellect, understanding, level of knowledge and mental capacity, or do I use the same manner and method of speaking everywhere?
- (3) Do I invite towards Islam while understanding the circumstances, the requirements of the age and people's situations, or do I simply say what suits my mood, temperament and disposition without considering the circumstances and the psychology of those I am addressing?
- (4) When inviting towards Islam, do I use simple, clear and comprehensible language instead of difficult and complicated words, or do I engage in such speech that the person being addressed finds difficult to understand?
- (5) Do I give people glad tidings of Allah Almighty's mercy, reward and Paradise for good deeds, while also warning them of the consequences of sins, punishment and the Hereafter, or do I always merely frighten them or merely give them hope?
- (6) Does my counsel contain sincere concern, compassion, gentleness and heartfelt sympathy, or do I call harshness, severity, anger and a bitter tone "inviting towards Islam"?
- (7) In order to reform people, do I highlight their good qualities and draw their attention to their shortcomings using gentle words, or do I merely point out their faults—and that too through humiliation, degradation, taunts, reproach and harsh criticism—thereby distancing them even further from religion?
- (8) Does the variation in my tone of voice, the beauty of my words and my manner of expression attract people's hearts, or do I consider shouting, roaring and a harsh tone to be an effective way of inviting towards Islam?
- (9) In debate and discussion, do I base my arguments on evidence, justice and scholarly principles, or do I resort to shouting and uproar, sophistry, deception and methods intended merely to put the other person down?

(10) When debating with an opponent, do I have a genuine concern for the well-being of Muslims, or does my manner of debate contradict this?

(11) Do I disregard an opponent's personal attacks, harsh speech and attempts to cause distress and remain focused on the main subject, or do I respond to a personal attack with another personal attack and thereby lose sight of the actual objective?

(12) Do I speak to those who hold differing views with gentleness, forbearance, patience, tolerance and good character, or do I even begin to express anger, abusive language, mockery and hatred when I disagree with my own people?

One Final Question

A person who invites towards Islam should consider: Could it be that, while calling people towards the path of Allah Almighty, I am actually distancing them from the path of Allah Almighty because of my manner of inviting them?

May Allah Almighty grant us the ability to adopt, in inviting towards righteousness and serving Islam, the method that He loves and that His Beloved ﷺ adopted.

أَمِينَ بِجَاهِ خَاتَمِ النَّبِيِّينَ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَآلِهِ وَسَلَّمَ

11 August 2026

اَلْحَمْدُ لِلّٰهِ رَبِّ الْعَالَمِيْنَ وَالصَّلٰوةُ وَالسَّلَامُ عَلٰى سَيِّدِ الْمُرْسَلِيْنَ اَمَّا بَعْدُ فَاَعُوْذُ بِاللّٰهِ مِنَ الشَّيْطَانِ الرَّجِيْمِ بِسْمِ اللّٰهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيْمِ



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